MANALIVE EXPEDITION

THE JOURNEY

WEEK 9
BAND OF BROTHERS

WHO HAS YOUR BACK?

DRAFT FOR REVIEW

October 12, 2026

WEEK 9 OVERVIEW

WHAT THIS WEEK IS FOR

Week 9 walks a man back through Sunday morning's Band of Brothers session. Beta readers said the app gave the why of brotherhood but not the how, so every reading this week ends with one concrete step, and every step starts with Dad. By Sunday he should be able to say:

> *I can't do this alone. I can see how I've protected myself from other men, and maybe why. I want brothers who are committed, who know my story, and who have my back. Not cops. Men who fight for my heart, and laugh, and forgive, and show up. And I want it enough to risk being known, and to become that kind of brother for somebody else.*

HOW EVERY DAY WORKS

READING	About 150 words. A quick reminder of what happened at camp and where it shows up at home. This week each one ends with "Today:" and one small step.
AUDIO	About 2 minutes from John. A handle to carry, one layer deeper, and a story.
WITH DAD	5 minutes on weekdays this week. Saturday is 10. Sunday is 3.
SHARE	Optional. Opens the alumni group with his thought ready to paste.
NOTES	Private. Day 63 shows him this week's notes in one place.
WEEKLY EMAIL	Sunday evening. One heart line per day.

THE WEEK AT A GLANCE

DAY	TITLE	CARRY THIS	WITH DAD
57 · Mon	Where's My Buffalo?	**You can't do this alone**	5 min
58 · Tue	Lone Wolf, Social Butterfly	**Who actually knows me?**	5 min
59 · Wed	Brother Wounds	**The wound doesn't get the last word**	5 min
60 · Thu	Start With One	**Start with one**	5 min
61 · Fri	Somebody Goes First	**Somebody has to go first**	5 min
62 · Sat	Not a Cop	**Brothers fight for the heart**	10 min
63 · Sun	Who Has Your Back?	**Whose back do I have?**	3 min

BEFORE YOU RECORD

YOUR STORIES

Answer these however is easiest: talk, scribble, bullet points. Each one drops into that day's audio script.

DAY 57 · WHERE'S MY BUFFALO?

When's a time you carried something heavy by yourself that you could have handed to somebody? What was it, and how long did you carry it?

DAY 59 · BROTHER WOUNDS

Was there a man in your life, a brother, a friend, a teammate, who let you down when it counted? What happened, and what did you tell yourself afterward?

DAY 60 · START WITH ONE

When you moved to Wisconsin and had to start over, how did you and Bill actually get going? Who reached out first, and what did those first few times look like?

DAY 63 · WHO HAS YOUR BACK?

Tell about a time you and one of your brothers hurt each other or let each other down. What happened, and how did you find your way back?

WHERE'S MY BUFFALO?

READING

Sunday morning. Coffee in hand, tired from the weekend, and the first thing on the screen was a guy riding a buffalo.

You laughed. You were supposed to. After everything that weekend, you'd earned it.

Then one sentence: *You cannot do this alone*.

Not because you're weak. A man can get a lot done alone. Build a business. Raise kids. Fix the truck. What he can't do alone is live with his whole heart. Not for long.

You're eight weeks home. Whatever God did at camp, the ordinary world has been quietly talking you into carrying it by yourself. Politely. Like that's the responsible thing.

This week is about the men. Not just why. How. One step a day.

And the first step is the one every band of brothers starts with. You decide you want one.

Today: Tell Dad, out loud if you can, *I want brothers*. That's the whole step.

> **CARRY THIS**
>
> **You can't do this alone.**

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

I'm not going to find a deep spiritual lesson in that buffalo. Believe me, I've looked. About all I've got is this: the guy went off by himself, and it didn't go great.

I've been that guy.

> **YOUR STORY**
>
> *When's a time you carried something heavy by yourself that you could have handed to somebody? What was it, and how long did you carry it?*

That's what most of us do. Not because we're tough. Because nobody showed us another way. Somewhere along the line we learned a real man handles it. Keeps it in the house. Doesn't bother anybody.

> And you can get a long way like that. But here's what I've learned. A man can accomplish a lot alone. He can't live wholehearted alone.
>
> Sooner or later, life comes for every one of us. A diagnosis. A kid in trouble. A marriage in a hard place. Or just a slow drift you don't notice until you're way out. The question isn't whether that day comes. It's whether anybody knows you well enough to notice.
>
> **So here's what I want you to carry today. You can't do this alone.**
>
> Not as a guilt trip. As permission. You were never supposed to.
>
> And if you don't have guys like that right now, hear me. That doesn't mean something's wrong with you. It means you're at the starting line. Every one of us started there.
>
> Brotherhood doesn't start with a program or a sign-up sheet. It starts with a man deciding, I'm done doing this by myself.
>
> So make that decision today. Go to Dad and tell Him. Father, I want brothers. Then ask Him to start showing you who.
>
> You can't do this alone. And you don't have to.

WITH DAD 5 MINUTES

Ask Him: *Father, what am I carrying alone right now?* Listen. Then tell Him: *I want brothers*. If it feels awkward, say it anyway. That's the decision.

SHARE

What's one thing that's easier with a few good men than alone?

YOUR NOTES

LONE WOLF, SOCIAL BUTTERFLY

READING

Remember the three ways to live?

The Lone Wolf. *I don't need anybody*. Underneath it, a lot of times: *I learned not to need anybody*.

The Social Butterfly. Knows everybody. Everybody knows his name. Nobody knows his heart.

The Brother. The one who risks being known.

Here's what got said at camp, and it matters: these aren't personality types. The quiet guy can have deep brothers. The loud guy can be the loneliest man in the room. It's not about how many people you talk to. It's about what you do with your heart.

The wolf and the butterfly are doing the same thing. Protecting themselves. And when life puts them on the ground, they end up in the same place. Nobody to call.

Today: On a scrap of paper, write the names of the men who know your real story. Not your highlight reel. Your story. If the list is short, or blank, that's okay. That's where you start.

> CARRY THIS
> **Who actually knows me?**

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

> I can walk into a party of fifty people and not know a soul, and within an hour I'll know twenty of them. That's just how I operate.
>
> For a long time I thought that meant I had a lot of friends.
>
> Here's what I figured out. Just because I can talk to twenty people doesn't mean I know any of them. Or that any of them know me.
>
> I was a social butterfly my whole life. A driven people pleaser. I'd crack jokes with you. Have a beer with you. You'd walk away liking me. But I'd never let you get a peek inside. Never let you see where I was hurting.
>
> Why? Because if you saw the real thing, you might not like it. And I needed you to like me.

Now some of you are the opposite. You're not at the party. You're out in the truck. You don't need anybody, and you'd like everybody to quit asking.

Different look. Same move. We're both protecting ourselves. And here's the problem. When life puts you on the ground, the wolf has nobody, and the butterfly has a thousand contacts and nobody to call.

So here's what I want you to carry today. Who actually knows me?

Not who likes me. Not who I see every week. Who knows the real story?

Ask it honestly. No beating yourself up. If the answer is nobody, that's not a verdict on you. It's just where you are today. And the truth is always a better place to start than the act.

Then take it to Dad. He already knows the whole story. Every page. And He hasn't gone anywhere.

Ask Him what you've been protecting. Who actually knows me? Start there.

WITH DAD 5 MINUTES

Ask Him: *Father, which one have I been? What was I protecting?* Then listen. Whatever comes, there's no shame in it. You're just getting honest about the starting line.

SHARE

Lone Wolf or Social Butterfly: which one is your default?

YOUR NOTES

BROTHER WOUNDS

READING

Sunday morning, before anybody talked about what makes a brother, the room got quiet.

We prayed. *Jesus, if there's a wound from a brother or another man that still keeps me guarded, bring it to mind.*

Maybe a face came up. A blood brother. A buddy who disappeared when you needed him. A teammate. A group that turned on you. A guy who told something you trusted him with.

Wounds like that leave a message behind. *Men can't be trusted. I'll do it myself. If they really know me, they'll leave. Nobody comes through for me.*

If you've been slow to let men in, there may be a real reason. That's worth honoring. Being known is dangerous when men have hurt you before.

But that wound doesn't get to decide whether brotherhood is possible for you.

Today: Go back to that prayer with Dad. Same steps. You don't have to be finished, and you don't have to force anything.

> CARRY THIS
>
> **The wound doesn't get the last word.**

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

Some of you were ready to start a band of brothers on Monday. Others have been nodding along this week thinking, yeah, I tried that. It didn't go well.

I hear you.

> YOUR STORY
>
> *Was there a man in your life, a brother, a friend, a teammate, who let you down when it counted? What happened, and what did you tell yourself afterward?*

Here's what happens with a wound like that. The hurt fades some. But the message stays. And it starts making decisions for you.

You don't invite the guy to breakfast, and you tell yourself you're busy. You keep it light at the fire. You hold back one piece of your story, just in case.

That's not weakness. That's a man protecting himself. It made sense when it happened. It's just a lousy way to live for the next thirty years.

You don't have to dig up everything today. You already know how to take something to Jesus. You did it at camp. Do it again, small. One wound. One message. Ask Him what's true.

And if there's forgiveness you can offer, offer it. If there isn't yet, that's okay. Don't fake it. He's patient.

Here's what I want you to carry today. The wound doesn't get the last word.

It gets a word. It happened. It mattered. But it doesn't get to decide whether brotherhood is possible for you.

So go sit with Him for five minutes. Let Him take you back to that place, and listen for what He says. Then ask Him for the courage to try again with men.

The wound doesn't get the last word. He does.

WITH DAD 5 MINUTES

Go slowly. *Jesus, bring to mind a wound from a man that still keeps me guarded.* Pause. *What message did I take from it?* Pause. *What's true?* If you can release that man to Him today, do. If not yet, that's okay. If nothing comes up at all, just thank Him and sit.

SHARE

One thing you'd tell a guy who's been burned by other men.

YOUR NOTES

START WITH ONE

READING

Committed to each other. That was the first mark of a brother at camp.

Not casual. Not just guys you go to the game with. Men who decide to show up for each other, on purpose, before anybody's in a crisis.

So how do you actually find them? Nobody hands you a list.

Start with Dad. Ask Him who. Then look around with your eyes open.

The guys from your camp. Your table, your fire. The man at work or church who seems a little hungry for more. A guy who loves what you love: hunting, lifting, old trucks, early mornings on the water. That's often where it starts.

They might not be the guys you'd pick. That's fine. Some of the best groups look like nobody planned them.

And you don't need six. You need one.

Today: Pick one man. Text him and set a time. Breakfast, coffee, a walk. Put it on the calendar today, not someday.

> CARRY THIS
> **Start with one.**

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

> A few years back, I moved to Wisconsin. I had five guys back home who would do anything for me. Ten years together.
>
> Those guys still had my back. But they weren't down the street. And I learned real fast: I needed brothers where I was.
>
> > YOUR STORY
> > *When you moved to Wisconsin and had to start over, how did you and Bill actually get going? Who reached out first, and what did those first few times look like?*
>
> That's how it starts. Not with a group. With one guy.

> Most of us wait. We figure we'll get closer to that guy someday, when life slows down.
>
> Life doesn't slow down. If you wait until you've got spare time for brotherhood, you probably won't have brotherhood. Somebody has to put it on the calendar.
>
> So here's the how, plain. Ask Dad who. Pick one man. Not a perfect one. Just one who seems a little hungry, or who loves the same stuff you do. Text him. Hey, want to grab breakfast Thursday? I'd like to get to know you better.
>
> It'll feel a little awkward. Do it anyway. Most guys are just waiting for somebody else to ask.
>
> Then show up. And show up again. Commitment isn't a big speech. It's the second breakfast. And the fifth one.
>
> **Here's what I want you to carry today. Start with one.**
>
> One man. One time on the calendar.
>
> And if he says no, or he flakes, that's okay. It doesn't mean you were wrong to ask. Go back to Dad and ask Him who's next.
>
> Start with one. Go ask Him who.

WITH DAD 5 MINUTES

Ask Him: *Father, who? Give me one name.* Listen. Write down whoever comes to mind, even if it surprises you. Then, before the day's over, text him.

SHARE

Post your town and one thing you love to do. See who's close.

YOUR NOTES

SOMEBODY GOES FIRST

READING

Know each other's stories. The second mark of a brother.

If a man doesn't know your story, he can't tell when you're hiding inside it. And if you don't know his, it's easy to judge what you don't understand.

Remember your fire at camp? Somebody had to talk first. After that it got easier for everybody.

It works the same way at home. Somebody has to go first. It might be you.

You don't have to tell it all at once. Start with where you came from. Your dad. What hurt. Where you are now. Then ask for his. Brothers learn each other's stories over years, not over one breakfast.

And this part isn't optional: his story belongs to him. You can tell your wife your story. Not his. Not even the safe-sounding parts.

Today: Think of the man you texted yesterday. Decide one true thing about you that you'll tell him next time you're together.

> CARRY THIS
> **Somebody has to go first.**

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

> Seventeen years ago, I was sitting at a fire in the woods at camp with a handful of guys. No agenda. Everybody was raw from the weekend. We were laughing a little. Mostly just sitting there.
>
> And I said, guys, I've got to tell you my story.
>
> I want you to hear this. It wasn't because I was brave. I was at my wit's end. I'd made so many mistakes, I'd about run out of options. God had moved that weekend, so I figured, okay. Maybe I'll just give this a shot.
>
> So I told them. Things I'd never told another human being.
>
> And something happened. By two-thirty that morning, every man at that fire had told his story. That night is where my band of brothers started.

It didn't take a great man. It took one guy willing to go first.

Now, you don't have to unload your whole life at your first breakfast. Trust gets built a piece at a time. You tell a little. He handles it well. You tell a little more.

But somebody has to go first. And if you wait for the other guy, you might wait forever. He's probably waiting on you.

So here's what I want you to carry today. Somebody has to go first.

And when he tells you his story, guard it. It's his. Not your wife's. Not your small group's. His. The day a man finds out his story got passed around, the trust is gone.

Today, go to Dad first. Ask Him what part of your story you've never let a man see. And ask Him for the guts to go first.

Somebody has to go first. Why not you?

WITH DAD 5 MINUTES

Ask Him: *Father, what part of my story have I never let a man see?* Listen. Then: *Who do You want to hear it?* You don't have to act on it today. Just let Him show you.

SHARE

What makes you trust a man with your story?

YOUR NOTES

NOT A COP

READING

Then came the greatest brotherhood clip ever found.

Ricky Bobby in a wheelchair, sure he's paralyzed. His buddies tell him the truth: it's all in your head. He gets furious. Then he stabs his own leg with a knife to prove he can't feel it. He can. And they stay right there and help get it out.

You laughed till you cried. But there was something real in it. A brother tells you the truth you can't see. He risks you getting mad. He doesn't leave when it gets messy.

Then came the line that surprised some guys. Brotherhood isn't an accountability group.

Not because truth doesn't matter. Because a cop and a suspect aren't brothers. A checklist asks, *Did you do it?* A brother asks, *What's going on in your heart that you reached for that?*

Brothers don't police behavior. They fight for the heart.

Today: Learn the question. *How's your heart?* And when he answers, the next one: *What's underneath that?*

CARRY THIS

Brothers fight for the heart.

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

I want to tell you about the first time I told my brothers I'd looked at porn.

I knew what was coming. The religious answer. Get an accountability partner. Put the software on your phone. Did you pray? Did you read your Bible? I figured I'd get the lecture, and maybe that look. The disappointed one.

So I said it. Guys, I looked at porn this week.

And they didn't do any of that.

They said, thank you for sharing that. And then, I wonder what was underneath it. What were you trying to cover up? What were you trying to feel? What were you trying to escape?

They went after my heart.

I can't tell you what that did in me. I was braced for harsh, and they were gentle. Not soft. Nobody pretended it was fine. They just cared more about me than about the behavior.

That's the difference. A checklist makes one man the cop and the other man the suspect. And you know what a suspect does? He lies, or he leaves.

A brother knows your story well enough to ask what you were reaching for. Because the screen, or the bottle, or blowing up at your wife, is almost never the real thing. It's a man reaching for life in a place he already knows is death to him.

So here's what I want you to carry today. Brothers fight for the heart.

And here's how, practically. Every week, with your guys, or your one guy, ask it: How's your heart? Wait for the real answer. When something comes out, don't fix it. Don't preach. Ask: What's underneath that? Then pray for him, right there.

It's Saturday. Take ten minutes with Dad. Let Him ask you what's underneath. Nobody asks it more gently than He does.

Then ask Him whose heart He wants you to fight for.

Brothers fight for the heart. Starting with yours.

WITH DAD 10 MINUTES

Take your time. Think about what you've been reaching for lately: a screen, a drink, your temper, staying busy. Let Him ask you: *What's underneath it? What were you really looking for?* Listen, and write down what comes. Then ask: *Father, whose heart do You want me to fight for?*

SHARE

What's a question that gets past "fine"?

YOUR NOTES

WHO HAS YOUR BACK?

READING

Nine weeks home.

The last thing you saw that Sunday morning was Act of Valor. Men on a mission. One of them hit. Everything going sideways. And one question, over and over: *Who has your back?*

Nobody explained it. Nobody had to.

Look back at the road you've walked since. Your heart, still alive. A larger story, and a red dot. The poser you built to survive. The wound underneath it. The name your Father calls you. A battle, an adventure, beauty. And this week, brothers.

That's a lot of ground. You didn't walk it perfectly. Nobody does. But you're still here.

Your notes from this week are right below. Read back through them.

Today, rest. And turn the question around. Not only *who has my back?* But *whose back do I have?*

We keep going.

> **CARRY THIS**
> **Whose back do I have?**

AUDIO SCRIPT JOHN

Before this week's over, I want to be straight with you. Your brothers are going to let you down.

They'll miss a call. Say something dumb. Forget the part of your story that makes that joke hurt. And you'll do the same to them.

My guys and I have pushed each other right to the edge more than once.

YOUR STORY

Tell about a time you and one of your brothers hurt each other or let each other down. What happened, and how did you find your way back?

If your idea of brotherhood is nobody ever hurts me again, that isn't real. Real is men who trust each other's heart, own their part, forgive, and keep showing up.

And here's the turn. Act of Valor asks, who has your back? There's another question.

Whose back do I have?

This was never about building a rescue team around yourself. It's about becoming the guy somebody else can call.

Look back at these nine weeks. None of it was meant to be walked alone. Dad's been with you the whole way. And if you look, He's been bringing men too.

If you didn't text anybody this week, that's okay. The door's still open.

So today, rest. Read your notes. Text one guy and ask him how his heart is. Mean it.

Then take it to Dad. Father, whose back do You want me to have?

We keep going. I'll see you tomorrow.

WITH DAD 3 MINUTES

Look back with Him. Ask: *Father, what have You done in me these nine weeks?* Then: *Whose back do You want me to have?* Then just be with Him.

SHARE

One line about nine weeks home.

YOUR WEEK IN THE APP: HIS NOTES FROM DAYS 57 TO 63, FILLED IN

Same as Day 7: each note he wrote this week, with the day, the "Carry this" line, and the With Dad question. Only days he wrote show up.

YOUR NOTES ON DAY 63

SUNDAY EVENING, AFTER DAY 63

THE WEEK 9 EMAIL

Same template as Week 1. Only the seven day lines are new.

From: The Journey <jpulley@manaliveexpedition.com>
Subject: Week nine is in the books. You're caught up.

Mike,

Nine weeks home. Maybe you did every day. Maybe you missed a few. Either way, you're not behind, and there's nothing to apologize for. Here's the heart of the week, in case any of it slipped by.

Day 57, Where's My Buffalo? A man can get a lot done alone. He can't live wholehearted alone. The first step is a decision: I want brothers. **Reread Day 57 ›**

Day 58, Lone Wolf, Social Butterfly. Different look, same move: protecting your heart. The honest question is, who actually knows me? **Reread Day 58 ›**

Day 59, Brother Wounds. If men have hurt you, being slow to trust makes sense. But the wound doesn't get the last word. **Reread Day 59 ›**

Day 60, Start With One. Brotherhood doesn't start with a group. It starts with one man and one time on the calendar. **Reread Day 60 ›**

Day 61, Somebody Goes First. If he doesn't know your story, he can't tell when you're hiding in it. Somebody has to go first. And his story stays his. **Reread Day 61 ›**

Day 62, Not a Cop. A checklist asks, did you do it? A brother asks what's underneath. Brothers fight for the heart. **Reread Day 62 ›**

Day 63, Who Has Your Back? Brothers let each other down and come back anyway. The better question is, whose back do I have? **Reread Day 63 ›**

Your notes from this week are waiting for you on Day 63. Only you can see them.

Read your week ›

That's the week. If you just read this, you're caught up. Tomorrow we start fresh.

Strength and Honor,
Pulley

FOR YOUR REVIEW

DECISIONS MADE IN THIS DRAFT

- **A practical week.** Beta readers asked for the how, so every reading ends with a bolded "Today:" step: decide, take an honest inventory, pray through one wound, text one man, go first, learn the heart question, have somebody's back. The steps borrow from the five your 2019 band gave on stage (make the decision, ask God, make a covenant, tell your stories, fight for it). Every step starts with Dad. This "Today:" line is new to the format; confirm you want it.
- **One day per piece of the session,** in camp order: the thesis (57), three ways to live (58), brother wounds (59), committed (60), know each other's stories (61), Ricky Bobby and not accountability (62), Act of Valor and brothers failing each other (63).
- **Held story used: your brothers meeting your porn confession with gentleness** (Day 62, Saturday). Written in your voice from the facts given. Check the wording, especially "I was braced for harsh, and they were gentle."
- **Your own 2019 TX stories, retold briefly. Please confirm each:**
  - Day 58: the party of fifty, knowing twenty in an hour, "a driven people pleaser, social butterfly my whole life."
  - Day 60: moving to Wisconsin, five guys back home who'd do anything for you, needing brothers where you are. Used as the setup for a story slot about how you and Bill started. If Bill or Wisconsin is out of date, swap the slot question.
  - Day 61: the fire in the woods, at your wit's end, telling things you'd never told anyone, everyone sharing by 2:30 a.m. In the 2019 talk Darryl told it and you confirmed it. "Seventeen years ago" assumes 2009, matching Week 1.
  - Day 63: one line, "my guys and I have pushed each other right to the edge," before the story slot.
- **4 story slots** (Days 57, 59, 60, 63). The jail story isn't invited; nothing here clearly needed it.
- **Brother wounds named gently, one day only,** as one reason men resist. Day 59 uses the camp's own short prayer steps, prays rather than teaches, and doesn't force forgiveness or reteach Healing Prayer.
- **Accountability is not attacked as a word.** The "accountability is bullshit" line isn't used. The distinction is cop and suspect versus a brother who asks what's underneath.

- **Confidentiality** is stated plainly on Day 61: his story belongs to him, not your wife, not your small group.
- **No panel, no Fire logistics, no sign-up.** The one practical nudge toward other alumni is Day 60's Share: post your town and what you love to do, and see who's close.
- **Leadership's unloaded model lines** ("six guys exchanged phone numbers," the "I will know you" transition) are not used. Day 60 paraphrases the coach's concept that if you wait for spare time, you won't have brotherhood.
- **Ricky Bobby is named** in the app, since the surprise is already spent at camp. Act of Valor is quoted only as "Who has your back?"
- **Day 63 lands the whole journey** as a look-back without announcing an ending. It assumes Weeks 3 to 8 are Poser, Wound, New Name, Battle, Adventure, Beauty. If Sonship gets its own week, or the order differs, adjust that one sentence. It closes on "We keep going."
- **"Brother" is used only as a noun,** never as a greeting.
- **With Dad** is 5 minutes on weekdays, 10 on Saturday, 3 on Sunday.

OVERALL NOTES ON WEEK 9